Chapter One

Curzon, Russia and the Great Game

In the mid-nineteenth century, a young British officer serving in Afghanistan came to believe that it was his 'mission to frustrate Russian schemes of conquest in Central Asia and convince its independent Muslim rulers to band together and seek British protection'. What Arthur Conolly wanted most, he wrote to a friend in 1841, was to play a leading role in this 'great game' in Central Asia. Rudyard Kipling's Kim might have helped the term to enter British lexicon, but it was a real life Great Game player who had first coined the phrase. [1] Indeed, within a year of writing to his friend, the unfortunate Conolly would have met an end seemingly taken from the pages of fiction. Having travelled to Bokhara on a mission to rescue a fellow British officer, Colonel Charles Stoddart, from the hold of the capricious emir, Conolly found himself also taken captive. After spending a tortuous few months in a bug infested pit, Conolly and Stoddart were finally executed in 1842 – a death perhaps befitting the ultimate Great Gamer. [2]

If only Conolly could have known the place he would come to occupy in the history books. For the expression he used would become so ubiquitous in the twentieth century that it would end up being used by politicians, journalists and writers to refer to almost any conflict in Asia or the Middle East that involved outside powers. Indeed, for some, the collapse of the USSR and the subsequent opening up of Central Asia has precipitated a second wave of international interest in the region that has come to be known as the 'new Great Game' – a phrase even used to describe the recent war in Afghanistan. And what was once a game played only between Britain and Russia, has now found a third player in the form of the USA.

Yet, the 'Great Game' is not merely a general catchphrase to be applied to any and every issue arising in Asia. Instead, it is an important concept in